

MPF-1001, features an audio cassette adapter—something to keep in mind for car owners who like music. You can hook up your PMP to your cassette audio system—save space by dumping all those cassettes lying in your glove compartment. All these PMPs can be used as plug-n-play USB drives: convergence at work again...

Performance

Performance has always been a function of price. We were interested to see if any of the minnows could buck this trend. In terms of sheer music performance, nothing beat the YES YMP-18 in this category. This little player had no issues driving the Bose intra-ear headphones, and producing some good highs and deep bass. The Mitashi MPF-1001 also deserves a mention for good sound, as does the MobiBlu DAH-2100 and the YES YMP-35. Although just behind the YMP-18 is terms of quality, the MPF-1001 did have a slightly higher maximum volume, which is a good thing for noisy environments. The YMP-35 has relatively lower maximum volumes, although it has an excellent equaliser which does boost volume quite a bit (from normal settings), all this without any noticeable distortion in quality.

A word on the default earphones on our little maestro (YMP-18): they're not quite the best. If you enjoy clear, well defined sound, you might want to consider getting a better set.

The Eurone 838S and the Root VJE-1GB are a little short on sound quality—if this is an important consideration, overlook these two options.

The other half of performance is battery life. After all, no-one wants a good PMP that gives out on you within a couple of hours. And this is

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MobiBlu DAH-2100
Small sight, big sound

where YES loses out to the likes of Mitashi and MobiBlu—at nearly one third of the music time of the MobiBlu player, the YMP-18 is definitely not marathon material.

Boiling It Down

For its combination of features, sound music performance and stellar battery life, we've awarded MobiBlu's DAH-2100 with our Digit Best Buy Gold award. The combination of good MP3 playback capabilities, a great equaliser, and a cool screen catapult the YES YMP-35 into second spot and earn it a well-deserved Digit Best Buy Silver.

If music performance is of primary importance and you can do without a colourful screen, the YES YMP-18 makes a decent deal—just remember to add the cost of a good set of earplugs, Creative's EP630 for example! We'd say it was a terrific deal if only it didn't have the double whammy of poor battery life and costly AAA batteries. However, in this price category, nothing beats it acoustics-wise. If you want a good balance between looks, performance, and features, including a decent screen for movies, the Mitashi MPL-1004 makes for a good buy.

THE INTERMEDIATES Rs 4,001 to Rs 6,500

Populated by eight players, this category hits the sweet spot between performance and price. Although nearly all the sub-4001 rupee players already boast of most of the features we thought we'd only see this category onwards, there's the little matter of quality to deal with, both in terms of build and sound. This is the category where performance starts to get as important as features. Although definitely not in audiophile territory, it's a milestone on that path.

How We Tested

For our PMP test, we first categorised the players into price brackets as follows:

1. Up to Rs 4,000
2. Rs 4,001 to Rs 6,500
3. Rs 6,501 to Rs 10,000
4. Rs 10,001 and above

Features

The following parameters were looked at when it came to features:

1. Capacity (GB)
2. Size of Display
3. Upgradeable Memory
4. Presence of FM Tuner
5. Voice Recording
6. Photo Viewing and Video Playback

Besides this, we looked at player features like support for custom playlists, screen brightness adjustments, number of equaliser modes, support for custom equaliser settings, and inbuilt speakers. We also looked at useful features like inbuilt stopwatch functionality, as well as support for contacts, calendar and alarms. Extra points were awarded for extra features like camera functionality, games, and gimmicky but useful features such as touchscreen interfaces.

Performance

To gauge performance, we used a mix of test tracks that test the aural capabilities of any music device at varying frequencies. We listened for certain nuances present in the tracks that many audio devices have problems reproducing. All the audio test files were encoded at high-quality settings to MP3 format at 320 kbps. We used CBR (Constant Bit Rate) to ensure quality.

Rather than use the bundled headphones, we tested all the players on a set of reference headphones—the Bose Intra ear headphones, which offer superb quality and comfort. After rating each player, we tested their bundled headphones and rated them as compared to the excellent Bose on a scale of 10.

To test the performance of the players while transferring data, we used a set of 10 files each of 10 MB. The MBps figure is achieved as follows:

Transfer speed (MBps) = (total file size (100MB in this case))/(seconds taken for the transfer)

For our battery life test, we played the same MP3 test files (320 kbps) on each player, with the screen powered off and the bundled headphones plugged in. Music volume was kept between 50 and 65 per cent of the maximum on the basis of what sounded good to the ears on each player (not too muted). All equaliser settings were turned off.